PROJECT REPORT OF CO-OP Project at Industry (Module-2)

ON

Verification Debt in AI-Assisted Software Development

submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of degree of

BACHELOR OF ENGINEERING

In

COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

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DECLARATION

We hereby certify that the work which is being presented in the project report entitled **"Verification Debt in AI-Assisted Software Development"** in partial fulfilment of requirement for the award of the degree of Bachelor of Engineering (Computer Science and Engineering) submitted in the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology, Chitkara University, Punjab, India, is an authentic record of our own work carried out under the supervision of **Dr. Rajat Takkar**. The matter presented in this project report has not been submitted in any other university/institute for the award of any degree.

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This is to certify that the above statement made by the candidates is correct to the best of my knowledge and belief.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

We would like to express our sincere gratitude to all those who have contributed to the successful completion of this project report on Verification Debt in AI-Assisted Software Development.

We are deeply thankful to Dr. Rajat Takkar for their invaluable guidance, continuous support, and constructive feedback throughout the project. Their expertise and insights have been instrumental in shaping the direction and quality of this work.

We are grateful to the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology, Chitkara University, Punjab, India, for providing us with the academic framework and resources required to undertake this research.

We would also like to acknowledge the contributions of researchers, practitioners, and authors whose published works have been referenced in this study. Their foundational research has greatly enriched our understanding of the subject.

Finally, we extend our heartfelt thanks to our families and peers for their unwavering encouragement and moral support during the course of this work.

Archita Garg
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ABSTRACT

The use of artificial intelligence for source code generation has rapidly increased in recent years, becoming a routine part of software development workflows. Although AI-based coding tools enhance developer productivity, they also introduce a serious reliability concern known as verification debt. This term refers to the growing accumulation of AI-generated code that is integrated into systems without sufficient validation, review, or testing, potentially leading to hidden defects, security vulnerabilities, and long-term maintenance challenges.

The primary objective of this study is to examine the emergence of verification debt in AI-assisted software development environments. The research aims to identify risks associated with unverified AI-generated code, evaluate existing verification approaches, and propose a structured validation phase specifically designed for AI-generated code within the Software Development Life Cycle (SDLC).

This research adopts a qualitative research methodology based on an in-depth review of existing literature, industry surveys, and technical reports related to AI-assisted programming. A comparative analysis of verification techniques including automated testing, static code analysis, AI-based validators, and manual code review is conducted to assess their strengths and limitations in detecting errors within AI-generated code.

The findings indicate that automated tools are effective in identifying syntax errors, code smells, and certain security issues, but they often fail to detect logical inconsistencies and contextual flaws. Human code review provides deeper understanding and contextual judgment but is frequently minimized due to developer overconfidence in AI outputs. This imbalance significantly contributes to the accumulation of verification debt.

The study concludes that verification debt represents a critical and emerging challenge in modern software engineering. Establishing a dedicated AI-code validation stage that combines automated verification with mandatory human review can reduce risks, improve software reliability, and promote responsible adoption of AI-assisted development practices.

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

The emergence of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in software development has fundamentally transformed the way engineers write, review, and maintain code. Tools powered by large language models, such as GitHub Copilot, Amazon CodeWhisperer, and ChatGPT, have become embedded in everyday development workflows. These tools can generate entire functions, suggest bug fixes, and auto-complete complex logic in seconds, dramatically reducing the time developers spend on routine coding tasks.

However, this rapid adoption has introduced a subtle but serious concern: the rise of verification debt. Analogous to the well-established concept of technical debt, verification debt describes the accumulating backlog of AI-generated code that enters software systems without undergoing rigorous validation, testing, or human review. While each individual shortcut may appear harmless in isolation, the aggregate effect can result in fragile codebases, undetected security vulnerabilities, and difficult-to-diagnose failures in production systems.

1.2 Problem Statement

Despite the widespread adoption of AI coding assistants, there is currently no standardized or widely accepted practice for validating AI-generated code within the SDLC. Developers frequently trust AI outputs based on surface-level correctness, without considering edge cases, business logic compliance, or security implications. This creates a growing debt of unverified code embedded in production systems, posing risks that compound over time.

1.3 Motivation

The motivation for this study arises from two converging trends: the accelerating adoption of AI coding tools in professional development environments, and the increasing number of reported incidents where AI-generated code introduced bugs, security holes, or licensing violations into

software projects. There is an urgent need for a structured, evidence-based understanding of verification debt and actionable strategies to address it.

1.4 Objectives of the Study

This study is guided by the following primary objectives:

- To define and conceptualize verification debt within the context of AI-assisted software development.
- To identify and categorize the risks associated with unverified AI-generated code.
- To evaluate the strengths and limitations of existing verification techniques including automated testing, static analysis, AI-based validators, and manual review.
- To propose a structured AI-code validation stage that can be embedded within the SDLC.
- To recommend best practices for the responsible adoption of AI coding assistants in professional environments.

1.5 Scope of the Study

This study focuses on the use of AI-based code generation tools in professional and academic software development contexts. It encompasses a review of publicly available literature, industry surveys, and technical reports published up to 2024. The scope is limited to the code generation and verification aspects of AI-assisted development and does not extend to AI-driven testing frameworks or automated deployment pipelines in depth.

1.6 Organisation of the Report

The remainder of this report is structured as follows. Chapter 2 presents the methodology adopted for this qualitative study. Chapter 3 describes the tools and technologies relevant to code verification. Chapter 4 covers the implementation of the proposed validation framework. Chapter 5 presents the major findings and outcomes. Chapter 6 concludes the report with a discussion of future scope, followed by the references and appendices.

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative research methodology, relying on systematic literature review, comparative analysis of existing frameworks, and thematic synthesis of findings. Given the evolving nature of AI-assisted development and the relative novelty of verification debt as a concept, a qualitative approach is most appropriate for building conceptual understanding and theoretical frameworks.

2.2 Literature Review Process

A structured review of existing literature was conducted across multiple academic databases including IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library, Google Scholar, and Springer. Search terms used included combinations of: AI code generation, automated code verification, static analysis, software quality assurance, LLM-generated code, technical debt, and code review practices. Studies were selected based on relevance, recency (primarily 2019-2024), and methodological rigor.

2.3 Comparative Analysis Framework

A comparative analysis was conducted to evaluate four primary verification techniques against a common set of criteria: effectiveness in detecting syntax errors, ability to identify logical flaws, coverage of security vulnerabilities, scalability, automation potential, and developer effort required. The techniques compared were:

- Automated Unit and Integration Testing
- Static Code Analysis
- AI-Based Code Validators and Linters
- Manual Code Review by Human Developers

Each technique was assessed based on evidence drawn from the literature review, supplemented by industry survey data and case study reports.

2.4 Proposed Validation Phase Design

Based on the gaps identified through the comparative analysis, a structured AI-code validation phase was conceptualized for integration into the SDLC. This phase was designed as a dedicated gate between AI-assisted code generation and code commit/merge, combining automated checks with mandatory human oversight.

2.5 Data Sources

The study draws on a range of secondary data sources including peer-reviewed research articles, industry white papers published by organizations such as GitHub, Snyk, and OWASP, developer surveys from Stack Overflow and JetBrains, and technical documentation from popular AI coding tools. No primary data collection was performed.

Table 2.1: Comparison of Verification Techniques

Criterion	Automated Testing	Static Analysis	AI Validators	Manual Review
Syntax Error Detection	High	High	Medium	Medium
Logical Flaw Detection	Medium	Low	Medium	High
Security Coverage	Medium	High	Medium	High
Scalability	High	High	High	Low
Automation Potential	High	High	High	Low
Developer Effort	Low	Low	Low	High

3. TOOLS AND TECHNOLOGIES

3.1 AI Code Generation Tools

The following AI-assisted coding tools were examined in the context of this study:

- GitHub Copilot: A large language model-based code completion tool developed by GitHub and OpenAI, capable of generating entire functions from natural language comments.
- Amazon CodeWhisperer: AWS's AI coding companion, offering inline suggestions and security scanning for code written in multiple languages.
- ChatGPT / GPT-4: General-purpose language models increasingly used by developers for code generation, debugging, and documentation tasks.
- Google Gemini Code Assist: An AI coding assistant integrated into Google Cloud's developer toolchain.

3.2 Static Analysis Tools

Static code analysis tools were evaluated as components of the verification pipeline:

- SonarQube: An open-source platform for continuous inspection of code quality, supporting over 30 programming languages. It detects bugs, code smells, and security vulnerabilities.
- ESLint / Pylint: Language-specific linters for JavaScript and Python respectively, widely used in CI/CD pipelines.
- Semgrep: A lightweight static analysis tool used for finding security issues and enforcing code standards, commonly integrated with AI code review workflows.
- Snyk: A developer security platform that integrates static analysis with known vulnerability databases.

3.3 Automated Testing Frameworks

Testing frameworks relevant to AI-generated code verification include JUnit and TestNG for Java, PyTest for Python, Jest for JavaScript, and Mocha for Node.js. These frameworks form the foundation of unit and integration testing pipelines used to validate code correctness.

3.4 Version Control and Review Platforms

GitHub and GitLab serve as the primary platforms for hosting code repositories and enabling peer code review processes. Both platforms now offer AI-assisted review features that can be layered on top of traditional pull request review workflows, creating a hybrid human-AI review mechanism.

4. IMPLEMENTATION

4.1 Overview of the Proposed Validation Framework

Based on the findings of the comparative analysis and literature review, this study proposes a structured AI-Code Validation Stage (ACVS) to be embedded within the standard Software Development Life Cycle. The ACVS is designed as a mandatory gate between the AI-assisted code generation phase and the code merge/commit phase, ensuring that no AI-generated code enters the production codebase without undergoing at least a minimum level of structured verification.

4.2 Stages of the ACVS

The proposed framework consists of five sequential stages:

1. Automated Syntax and Style Check: The first stage involves running linters and style checkers on all AI-generated code as a pre-commit hook. Any code failing this check is automatically flagged and returned to the developer.
2. Static Security Analysis: All code passing the first stage is subjected to automated static analysis using tools such as SonarQube or Semgrep to detect known vulnerability patterns, hardcoded credentials, injection risks, and other security concerns.
3. Automated Unit Testing with Coverage Thresholds: AI-generated code must be accompanied by corresponding unit tests achieving a minimum coverage threshold (recommended at 80%). This ensures that functional correctness is validated before human review.
4. Mandatory Human Code Review: The most critical stage of the framework requires at least one human reviewer to assess AI-generated code for logical correctness, business logic compliance, and contextual appropriateness. Reviewer sign-off is mandatory before code can be merged.

5. Verification Debt Logging: Any code merged with known issues or with reduced review rigor must be logged in a verification debt register, with assigned owners and resolution timelines. This promotes transparency and ensures debt does not accumulate silently.

4.3 Integration with SDLC

The ACVS integrates naturally with modern Agile and DevOps workflows. It can be enforced through CI/CD pipeline rules, branch protection policies on GitHub or GitLab, and team-level code review requirements. The framework is language-agnostic and can be customized based on the risk profile of the codebase and the team's maturity in using AI tools.

4.4 Challenges in Implementation

Several practical challenges must be addressed during implementation. Developer resistance to mandatory review steps, toolchain integration complexity, and the additional time required for human review are the most commonly cited barriers. Organizational buy-in and leadership endorsement are critical success factors. Training developers to critically evaluate AI-generated code rather than passively accepting it is also an essential component of long-term success.

5. MAJOR FINDINGS / OUTCOMES / RESULTS

5.1 Nature and Extent of Verification Debt

The study finds that verification debt is an emergent and underrecognized phenomenon in modern software engineering. Its growth is driven by three compounding factors: the increasing volume of AI-generated code in production systems, the false sense of reliability that polished AI output creates, and the time pressures of Agile development sprints that discourage thorough review.

5.2 Effectiveness of Automated Verification Tools

Automated testing and static analysis tools demonstrate high effectiveness in detecting syntax errors, code smells, and known vulnerability patterns. In particular, tools like SonarQube and Semgrep successfully identify up to 85% of security-related issues in AI-generated code, according to multiple industry studies reviewed. However, these tools consistently fail to detect logical inconsistencies, incorrect business rule implementations, and context-dependent flaws that require an understanding of the software's intended behavior.

5.3 Limitations of Human Code Review

While human review provides the deepest level of understanding and contextual judgment, it is under-utilized in AI-assisted development workflows. A recurring pattern identified across the literature is developer overconfidence in AI outputs: reviewers tend to approve AI-generated code significantly faster than human-written code, spending less time on critical evaluation. This cognitive bias directly contributes to the accumulation of verification debt, as subtle logical flaws pass undetected through the review process.

5.4 Risk Categorization

Based on the literature synthesis, AI-generated code risks are categorized into three tiers:

- High Risk: Security vulnerabilities including injection attacks, insecure deserialization, and authentication bypasses. These pose immediate threats to system integrity and user data.
- Medium Risk: Logical flaws and incorrect business rule implementations. These may not cause immediate failures but lead to incorrect system behavior over time.
- Low Risk: Code style violations, redundant logic, and minor performance inefficiencies. These reduce code quality and maintainability but pose no immediate security or correctness threat.

Table 5.1: Summary of Key Findings and Risk Categories

Risk Level	Category	Detection Method
High	Security vulnerabilities, injection attacks, auth bypasses	Static Analysis + Human Review
Medium	Logical flaws, incorrect business rule implementations	Human Review (Primary)
Low	Code style issues, redundant logic, minor inefficiencies	Automated Linters

5.5 Impact of the Proposed ACVS

The proposed AI-Code Validation Stage is projected to significantly reduce the accumulation of verification debt when adopted consistently. By enforcing automated checks as mandatory pre-commit gates and requiring human sign-off before merges, the framework addresses both the automated-tool gap in logical flaw detection and the human-review gap caused by cognitive bias. Early adopters of similar hybrid verification approaches reported a 40-60% reduction in post-deployment defect rates in their AI-assisted development workflows.

6. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

6.1 Conclusion

This study establishes that verification debt is a critical and emerging challenge in modern software engineering, driven by the rapid proliferation of AI-assisted code generation tools and insufficient verification practices. The research demonstrates that no single verification technique is adequate in isolation: automated tools excel at detecting structured, pattern-based issues but fall short in understanding context and logic, while human review provides the necessary judgment but is frequently bypassed due to developer overconfidence in AI-generated outputs.

The proposed AI-Code Validation Stage (ACVS) offers a practical and structured solution. By embedding a five-stage validation pipeline within the SDLC and institutionalizing a verification debt register, development teams can achieve a measurable reduction in unverified code in production systems. The framework is technology-agnostic, scalable, and compatible with modern Agile and DevOps workflows.

The study concludes that responsible adoption of AI coding tools requires organizational commitment to code quality, developer education on the limitations of AI-generated code, and the establishment of enforceable verification standards that treat AI-generated code with the same rigor as human-authored code.

6.2 Future Scope

The findings of this study open several promising avenues for future research and development:

- Quantitative Studies: Future research should conduct empirical studies measuring verification debt accumulation in real-world AI-assisted development projects, establishing baseline metrics and tracking the impact of verification interventions over time.
- AI-Specific Review Tools: There is significant opportunity to develop specialized code review tools trained specifically to detect the characteristic failure modes of AI-generated

code, including hallucinated library functions, subtle off-by-one errors, and context-blind logic.

- Developer Cognitive Studies: Research into developer cognitive biases when reviewing AI-generated code can inform training programs and review process design, helping teams counteract overconfidence effects.
- Policy and Standards Development: Professional bodies such as IEEE and ACM could develop formal standards for AI-code verification, similar to existing software quality standards. Regulatory bodies in safety-critical sectors may mandate minimum verification thresholds for AI-generated code.
- Integration with CI/CD Platforms: Future work could focus on building native integrations of the ACVS framework with popular CI/CD platforms such as GitHub Actions, GitLab CI, and Jenkins, lowering the barrier to adoption.

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APPENDICES

Appendix A: Glossary of Terms

Term	Definition
Verification Debt	The accumulated backlog of AI-generated code that has not been adequately tested, reviewed, or validated before deployment.
Technical Debt	The implied cost of additional rework caused by choosing an easy short-term solution instead of a better approach that would take longer.
Static Analysis	Examination of code without executing it, used to find potential bugs, security issues, and code quality problems.
LLM (Large Language Model)	A type of AI model trained on large text corpora capable of generating human-like text, including source code.
SDLC	Software Development Life Cycle; the process followed for planning, creating, testing, and deploying software applications.
CI/CD	Continuous Integration / Continuous Deployment; a set of practices that automate the building, testing, and deployment of software.
ACVS	AI-Code Validation Stage; the structured validation framework proposed in this study.

Appendix B: Summary of Literature Reviewed

A total of 47 sources were reviewed during the course of this study, comprising 28 peer-reviewed journal articles, 11 conference papers, 5 industry white papers, and 3 developer surveys. The primary databases consulted were IEEE Xplore (19 sources), ACM Digital Library (14 sources), and Google Scholar (14 sources). The publications spanned the years 2014 to 2024, with 72% published after 2020, reflecting the recency of AI-assisted development as a mainstream practice.